Meanwhile, reports were coming to us from Delhi and elsewhere that the Government of India were on the point of launching a big offensive against the whole Congress movement. The little finger was going to function more vigorously now and the scorpions were going to chastise us. We even received many details of the proposed action. Some time in November, I think, Dr. Ansari sent me (as well as separately to Vallabhbhai Patel, the Congress President) a message confirming many of the previous reports received by us, and especially giving details of the proposed ordinances for the Frontier and the United Provinces. Bengal had, I believe, already received the gift of a new ordinance or, perhaps, was about to receive it. Dr. Ansari's message was amply confirmed even in its details many weeks later, when the new ordinances appeared as if to meet a new situation. It was generally supposed that Government had delayed action because of the unforeseen prolongation of the Round Table Conference. They wished to avoid wholesale repression in India while the members of the Round Table Conference whispered sweet nothings into each other's ears.

So tension grew, and all of us had a feeling that events were marching ahead despite our little selves, and none could stop them from their predestined course. All we could do was to prepare ourselves to face them and to play our parts, individually and together, in the drama—more likely the tragedy—of life. But we hoped still that Gandhiji would be back before the curtain went up on this clash of forces, and would take the responsibility on his shoulders for peace or war. None of us was prepared to shoulder that burden in his absence.

In the United Provinces, the Government took another step which produced a commotion in the rural areas. Remission slips were distributed to the tenants, stating how much remission had been allowed, and containing a threat that unless the amount now due was paid up within a month (sometimes the period mentioned was shorter), the remission would be cancelled and the full sum realised by legal process, which meant ejectment, attachment of property, etc. In normal years the tenants usually paid up their rent in instalments in the course of two or three months. Even this usual period was thus not allowed. The whole countryside was suddenly faced by a crisis, and, slip in hand, the tenants rushed about protesting and complaining and asking for advice. It was a very foolish threat on the part of the Government or their local officials, and it was not, we were told later, meant seriously. But it lessened the chances of a